

out of it. This is not your home. This is a way station, a temporary resting spot until you find your footing.

Make sure you're paying for something—anything. Even if your parents offer, even if they insist that you can move back home for free, remember, nothing's free, not even this. Look at it this way: For every dime your parents spend to support you past eighteen, that's a dime they won't have when they're over sixty-five. Who's going to have to chip in then? You. So put some money in an account for them, whatever you can afford. Give it to them when you leave for good, or surprise them later when it's accumulated some interest.

Then, don't just sit there. Take out the garbage and mow the lawn. Do those dishes, cook that dinner, and drive your folks or siblings around to their appointments. When you move back home, the only advantage for your parents is that they have a young, healthy helper around as they head into their later years.

And be sure to bring all your technical savvy with you. Be useful. Update computer programs, clean out old files, show your folks how to use the latest technology, or tutor younger siblings.

Then get out there and find out what your old friends are doing. In other words, don't hide. They may provide valuable contacts for you if you're job-hunting or, more important, looking for a place to live. They've known you for years, so they can vouch for you.

Money Mistake: Your Kid Won't Leave Home

THE FIX: START THINKING LIKE A LANDLORD

This one's for parents: If you're complaining about Junior living in the basement, ask yourself if you've made it too easy for your kid to move back home. And if those are your kids at that restaurant I mentioned earlier, the ones who spend *your* extra money on fine dining, I have no sympathy for you. You've worked hard to make your home comfortable for your kids when they lived there—the pool, the video-game console, the massive TV in the family room, the cable, the high-speed wireless Internet. When they were in high school, yours was